

SOCIAL SKILLS WORKBOOK

For Kids with Autism

Activities for Ages 6-12

Fun exercises to build confidence in social situations

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A NOTE TO PARENTS AND CAREGIVERS:

This workbook uses clear, concrete language and visual supports.

Work through it together with your child at their pace.

Celebrate effort, not perfection. Every small step counts.

ACTIVITY 1: READING FACIAL EXPRESSIONS

People show their feelings on their faces. Here are clues to look for:

- HAPPY:** Corners of mouth go UP, eyes crinkle, cheeks lift
- SAD:** Corners of mouth go DOWN, eyebrows droop, eyes look watery
- ANGRY:** Eyebrows come together, lips press tight, jaw clenches
- SCARED:** Eyes go WIDE, mouth opens, eyebrows go UP
- SURPRISED:** Eyebrows go way UP, mouth makes an O shape
- DISGUSTED:** Nose wrinkles, upper lip goes up, eyes squint
- CONFUSED:** One eyebrow up, head tilts, mouth might twist to one side

MATCHING EXERCISE: Draw a line from the description to the feeling:

Someone smiling with crinkly eyes

Someone with a furrowed brow and tight lips

Someone with wide eyes and open mouth

Someone with droopy eyes looking down

Someone wrinkling their nose

ANGRY

HAPPY

DISGUSTED

SCARED

SAD

ACTIVITY 2: BODY LANGUAGE BASICS

People talk with their BODIES too, not just their words!

PERSONAL SPACE RULER:

Close friends/family: About 1-2 feet (arm's length)

This is for hugs and whispers

Friends and classmates: About 2-4 feet

This is for talking and playing

Acquaintances/teachers: About 4-6 feet

This is for classroom distance

Strangers: 6+ feet

This is for people you don't know

HOW TO CHECK: If someone leans AWAY, you might be too close.

Body Language Signals:

Arms crossed: might mean 'I don't want to talk right now'

Turning body away: might mean 'I want to leave'

Eye contact + nodding: means 'I'm listening'

Looking at phone/clock: might mean 'I need to go'

Leaning in: means 'I'm interested in what you're saying'

PRACTICE: What does each body language mean? Write your guess:

Someone yawning while you talk:

Someone smiling and facing you:

Someone tapping their foot fast:

ACTIVITY 3: CONVERSATION STARTERS

Starting a conversation can feel hard. Here are scripts that work!

AT SCHOOL:

'Hi! What did you do this weekend?'

'That looks cool! What are you working on?'

'Do you want to play with me at recess?'

'I like your [backpack/shoes/shirt]. Where did you get it?'

FILL IN THE SPEECH BUBBLE - What could you say?

You see a kid playing alone at recess. You say:

You sit next to someone new at lunch. You say:

A classmate has a book you like. You say:

CONVERSATION RULES:

1. Ask a question (shows you care about them)
2. Listen to their answer (don't plan what to say next)
3. Say something about what THEY said (not changing topic)
4. Take turns (like a tennis game - back and forth)

ACTIVITY 4: TAKING TURNS

Taking turns means everyone gets a chance. It applies to:

- Talking in conversation
- Playing games
- Using equipment at recess
- Answering questions in class
- Choosing activities

BOARD GAME SCENARIO: Practice taking turns!

Imagine you are playing a board game. Answer these:

While waiting for your turn, you can:

If you lose a turn, you could say:

If someone takes too long, you could say:

If you win, a kind thing to say is:

If you lose, a good response is:

ACTIVITY 5: MAKING FRIENDS STEP-BY-STEP

Step 1: NOTICE

Look for someone who seems friendly (smiling, open body)

Step 2: APPROACH

Walk over. Stand at comfortable distance (about 3 feet)

Step 3: GREET

Say 'Hi!' or wave. Use their name if you know it

Step 4: ASK

Ask a question or give a compliment

Step 5: LISTEN

Pay attention to what they say. Nod to show you hear them

Step 6: SHARE

Share something about yourself (keep it short)

Step 7: SUGGEST

If it's going well: 'Do you want to [play/sit together]?'

Step 8: ACCEPT

If they say no, that's okay! Try someone else. You did great for trying!

MY FRIENDSHIP GOAL THIS WEEK:

Someone I would like to get to know better: _____

ACTIVITY 6: HANDLING UNEXPECTED CHANGES

Sometimes plans change. That can feel really hard. Here is a plan:

SOCIAL STORY: When Plans Change

Sometimes things don't go the way I expected.

This can make me feel upset, angry, or confused.

These feelings are OKAY. Everyone has them.

When plans change, I can:

1. Take 3 deep breaths
2. Tell myself: 'I can handle this'
3. Ask: 'What is the new plan?'
4. Think: 'What CAN I control right now?'
5. Try the new plan. I might even like it!

If I'm still upset, I can ask for a break.

Changes are part of life. I am getting better at handling them!

MY CHANGE PLAN:

When things change unexpectedly, I will:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

My calm-down strategy: _____

ACTIVITY 7: UNDERSTANDING SARCASM & JOKES

Sometimes people say the OPPOSITE of what they mean. This is sarcasm.

CLUES THAT SOMEONE IS BEING SARCASTIC:

- Their voice goes flat or extra dramatic
- They roll their eyes
- What they say doesn't match the situation
- They might smirk (half smile)

EXAMPLES - What do they REALLY mean?

It's raining and someone says 'Great weather!'

They mean: the weather is BAD

You spill milk and mom says 'Nice job!'

She means: please be more careful

'Oh sure, I LOVE homework'

They mean: they don't like homework

YOUR TURN: What do they really mean?

'Oh wonderful, another test' means:

Friend says 'Thanks a lot' sarcastically means:

'I just LOVE waking up early' means:

ACTIVITY 8: ASKING FOR HELP SCRIPT

Everyone needs help sometimes. Here's how to ask:

1. Get their attention:

'Excuse me' or raise your hand or say their name

2. Be specific:

Say exactly what you need help with

3. Say please:

'Could you please help me with...'

4. Say thank you:

Always thank them after, even if they can't help

SCRIPTS TO PRACTICE:

At school: 'Ms./Mr. ____, I don't understand the directions. Could you explain step 2?'

With friends: 'Hey, could you help me with this? I'm stuck on ____.'

At home: 'Mom/Dad, I need help with _____. Can you show me how?'

At a store: 'Excuse me, could you help me find ____?'

WRITE YOUR OWN HELP SCRIPTS:

When I need help at school, I will say:

When I need help with friends, I will say:

ACTIVITY 9: JOINING A GROUP

Joining a group that's already playing can feel scary. Here's how:

1. WATCH first (stand nearby and observe what they're doing)
2. WAIT for a pause (don't interrupt in the middle)
3. WALK closer (but not too close - about 3 feet away)
4. ASK: 'Can I play too?' or 'Can I join?'
5. If YES: Follow their rules. Don't try to change the game.
6. If NO: Say 'Okay, maybe next time' and find something else.
(It's not about YOU - they might just have enough players)

PRACTICE SCENARIOS: What would you do?

Kids are playing tag at recess:

I would: _____

Classmates are building with blocks:

I would: _____

Friends are drawing together:

I would: _____

ACTIVITY 10: DEALING WITH BULLYING

Bullying is when someone is mean to you ON PURPOSE, more than once.

WHAT IS BULLYING vs. WHAT IS NOT:

IS bullying:

- Hitting/pushing on purpose
- Name-calling repeatedly
- Leaving you out to be mean
- Spreading rumors

Is NOT bullying:

- Accidentally bumping you
- Not wanting to play once
- Disagreeing with you
- Being in a bad mood

WHAT TO DO (Responses that work):

1. Walk away (this takes away their power)
2. Use a calm, firm voice: 'Stop. I don't like that.'
3. Find a safe person (teacher, counselor, parent)
4. Stay near other people (bullies target kids alone)
5. It is NEVER your fault. You deserve to be treated with respect.

My safe adults I can tell:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

ACTIVITY 11: SENSORY OVERLOAD COPING

Sometimes the world feels TOO MUCH - too loud, bright, or crowded.

That's called sensory overload. Here's your coping plan:

MY SENSORY TRIGGERS (check the ones that bother you):

- ☐ Loud noises (cafeteria, assemblies)
- ☐ Bright/flashing lights
- ☐ Certain textures (clothing tags, food)
- ☐ Strong smells
- ☐ Being touched unexpectedly
- ☐ Crowded spaces
- ☐ Too many people talking
- ☐ Certain sounds (chewing, tapping)

MY COPING CARDS (cut these out or copy them):

CARD 1: Take 5 deep breaths. Count them on my fingers.

CARD 2: Go to my quiet space (where?): _____

CARD 3: Use my noise-canceling headphones or earplugs

CARD 4: Squeeze my stress ball or fidget toy

CARD 5: Ask for a break: 'I need a few minutes please'

SOCIAL SITUATION: LUNCHTIME

SITUATION: You sit down and nobody talks to you.

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

- Look for someone sitting alone and say 'Can I sit here?'
- Bring a conversation topic (book, game, weekend plans)
- It's okay to eat quietly - not every lunch needs talking

What would YOU do in this situation?

How would you feel? (circle one)

Calm Nervous Excited Scared Okay Unsure

Rate your confidence to try this (1-10): _____

SOCIAL SITUATION: GROUP PROJECT

SITUATION: You have to work with kids you don't know well.

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

- Introduce yourself: 'Hi, I'm _____'
- Ask: 'What part do you want to do?'
- Listen to their ideas before sharing yours

What would YOU do in this situation?

How would you feel? (circle one)

Calm Nervous Excited Scared Okay Unsure

Rate your confidence to try this (1-10): _____

SOCIAL SITUATION: RECESS

SITUATION: Everyone seems to already be in groups.

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

- Look for someone on the edges (they might want company too!)
- Ask to join: 'Can I play?'
- Start your own activity - others might join you

What would YOU do in this situation?

How would you feel? (circle one)

Calm Nervous Excited Scared Okay Unsure

Rate your confidence to try this (1-10): _____

SOCIAL SITUATION: HALLWAY

SITUATION: Someone you know walks by.

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

- A simple wave or 'Hey!' is enough
- You don't need to have a full conversation every time
- Smile and keep walking - that counts as being social!

What would YOU do in this situation?

How would you feel? (circle one)

Calm Nervous Excited Scared Okay Unsure

Rate your confidence to try this (1-10): _____

SOCIAL SITUATION: CLASSROOM

SITUATION: The teacher asks you to work with a partner.

WHAT COULD YOU DO?

- Turn to the nearest person and say 'Want to be partners?'
- If someone asks you: say 'Sure!'
- Take turns reading/writing/speaking

What would YOU do in this situation?

How would you feel? (circle one)

Calm Nervous Excited Scared Okay Unsure

Rate your confidence to try this (1-10): _____

FRIENDSHIP MAINTENANCE CHECKLIST

Friendships need care, like a plant needs water! Check what you do:

- ☐ I say hi to my friends when I see them
- ☐ I ask my friends how they're doing
- ☐ I remember things they told me and ask about them
- ☐ I invite friends to play or hang out
- ☐ I share things (toys, snacks, turns)
- ☐ I listen when they talk (even if I want to talk about my thing)
- ☐ I say sorry when I mess up
- ☐ I am happy for them when good things happen
- ☐ I help them when they need it
- ☐ I accept when they want to play with other people too

My friend's name: _____

Something they like that I can ask about: _____

Something we both enjoy doing: _____

MY SOCIAL STRENGTHS

You have SO MANY strengths! Check the ones that are true for you:

- ☐ I am honest and say what I mean
- ☐ I am loyal to my friends
- ☐ I know a LOT about topics I love
- ☐ I follow the rules
- ☐ I notice details others miss
- ☐ I am kind to animals
- ☐ I am fair and believe in justice
- ☐ I can focus deeply on things I care about
- ☐ I am creative and think differently
- ☐ I am reliable - people can count on me

My TOP strength: _____

How my strength helps me make friends:

MY COMMUNICATION PREFERENCE CARD

Fill this out and share with teachers/friends so they understand you:

MY NAME: _____

I communicate best when:

I need extra time to:

Please DON'T:

It helps me when you:

When I'm overwhelmed, I need:

My special interests are:

The best way to get my attention:

I might not look at you, but I AM listening when:

WEEKLY SOCIAL GOALS - Week 1

My social goal this week: _____

Day	What I tried	How it went	Rating
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

Best moment this week: _____

What I want to try next week: _____

I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY SOCIAL GOALS - Week 2

My social goal this week: _____

Day	What I tried	How it went	Rating
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

Best moment this week: _____

What I want to try next week: _____

I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY SOCIAL GOALS - Week 3

My social goal this week: _____

Day	What I tried	How it went	Rating
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

Best moment this week: _____

What I want to try next week: _____

I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY SOCIAL GOALS - Week 4

My social goal this week: _____

Day	What I tried	How it went	Rating
Mon	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____

Best moment this week: _____

What I want to try next week: _____

I'm proud of myself for: _____